(1952–1957). He also served as minister in charge of steel, mines and fuel, railways, food and agriculture, and industries.

Nehru was his own foreign minister and therefore needed assistance at a political level. Because of Swaran Singh's well-known negotiating skills, Nehru started utilizing his services, for some important MEA-related assignments, including negotiations with China, Pakistan and other neighbouring countries. Most notable among these assignments were the several rounds of talks which Swaran Singh held with the then Pakistani foreign minister Zulfiqar Ali Bhutto in 1962–63 even though he (Swaran Singh) was minister for railways at the time. Lal Bahadur Shastri later appointed Swaran Singh as external affairs minister, which portfolio he handled in two spells, interspersed by two spells as defence minister.

In the parliamentary elections of 1977, the Congress had faced a complete rout in the north as a result of the anti-Emergency wave. My father-in-law Sardar Swaran Singh was no exception and lost his Jalandhar parliamentary seat. After serving as a cabinet minister for an unbroken spell of twenty-three years, followed by one and a half years as an MP, he vacated his official residence, 7 Krishna Menon Marg in New Delhi and, within the stipulated period of one month, shifted to his own house at 11 Link Road, Jalandhar.

Despite moving back to Jalandhar, he would visit New Delhi occasionally and stay with one of his four daughters. During the period October–November 1982, he mostly stayed with us at my officially allotted flat at Satya Marg in Chanakyapuri. Otherwise a man of few words and known for his discretion, it was mainly due to his stay with us that I came to know about developments related to an attempt at finding a negotiated peaceful settlement with the Akalis, in which he played a significant role.

Upon the request of the Akalis, Swaran Singh met Indira Gandhi in the first week of October 1982, soon after her return from a state visit to the US and apprised her of the message he had received from them. He impressed upon her the need to work out a face-saving formula for the Akalis to help them out of their predicament. She agreed to his suggestion and asked him to go ahead with his plan.